


**LEGACY ISSUE** Leaders of the DMK-led coalition protest the Centre's three-language policy in Chennai, Feb. 18

PTI

NATIONAL EDUCATION POLICY

# A LANGUAGE BATTLE IN TAMIL NADU

By Kaushik Deka

In an intensifying confrontation between the Tamil Nadu government and the Centre, chief minister M.K. Stalin has reinforced his unequivocal opposition to the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020, declaring that the state will not implement it. The core of this resistance stems from concerns over perceived Hindi language imposition, besides potential disruption to Tamil Nadu's long-established education model, and what the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) government views as a violation of cooperative federalism.

NEP 2020 has reintroduced the three-language formula, a concept first introduced in the 1968 NEP. The DMK sees this as a covert attempt to introduce Hindi through the backdoor. The earlier NEP advocated for Hindi to be a compulsory language across the nation. Hindi-speaking states were required to teach Hindi, English and a modern Indian language—preferably a south Indian one—while non-Hindi-speaking states were expected to teach the local regional language, Hindi and English.

In contrast, NEP 2020 offers much more leeway, not imposing any specific language on any state. "There will be a greater flexibility in the three-language formula, and no language